

AI Overviews and AI Mode

Present on roughly half of searches, cutting click-through by up to 58%, and citing pages that mostly do not rank.

Bottom line

AI Overviews appear on about **47%** of results, roughly **60% of searches now end without a click**, and when an Overview is present CTR can fall **up to 58%**. Meanwhile only about **38%** of cited sources come from the organic top ten. The traffic is genuinely shrinking and the citation slots are winnable by pages that do not rank.

The two surfaces

AI Overviews are the generated summary block above traditional results on a normal Google search. You did not opt in and the blue links still appear below.

AI Mode is a separate conversational search experience. No blue links, deeper fan-out, follow-up questions, and a far more aggressive selection process.

They behave differently and the difference is measurable:

	AI Overviews	AI Mode
Trigger	Automatic on ~47% of queries	User chooses it
Blue links	Still present below	Not the primary output
Organic top-10 citation overlap	~38%	14 to 17%

[practitioner]

AI Mode is the harsher environment. Roughly five in six cited sources there do not rank in the organic top ten for the query. If you only measure rankings, you are blind to nearly all of it.

The click impact, honestly

Metric	Value
AI Overviews present in results (Q1 2026)	~47%
Searches ending without a click	~60%
CTR drop when an AI Overview is present	up to 58%

[practitioner]

Read "up to 58%" precisely. It is a ceiling, not an average, and it varies enormously by query type. Informational queries with a complete answer available lose the most. Transactional, navigational and complex commercial queries lose much less, because the user still needs to go somewhere to act.

What this means for a client conversation: informational top-of-funnel traffic is structurally declining and will not recover. Commercial and transactional traffic is far more resilient. A content strategy weighted entirely toward informational blog traffic is exposed to this, and saying so early is more useful than explaining it after the decline shows up in a report.

The compensating finding, from Section 41's corpus: traffic referred from AI platforms converts at **4 to 5x** the rate of traditional search traffic. Fewer visitors, considerably better ones. That trade is not automatically bad, and it changes what you should be measuring.

How selection works

From Section 36: **200 to 500 candidate documents narrowed to 5 to 15 citations**, across **5 to 11 fan-out sub-queries**. [practitioner]

Observable patterns in what gets selected:

- **Direct answers to the specific sub-question**, not general coverage of the topic
- **Extractable passages** that stand alone, per Section 37
- **Recency**, especially where the query has any time sensitivity
- **Entity clarity**, per Section 40
- **Brand mentions**, per Section 34, correlating more strongly than links

What is demonstrably not required: ranking in the top ten, and structured data.

What to do about it

1. Track presence, not just position. For your target queries, record whether an AI Overview appears at all. That determines how much traffic the ranking is actually worth.

2. Reweight toward commercial intent. If informational queries are losing clicks and commercial ones are not, that is a content mix decision, not a formatting decision.

3. Optimize for the citation slot on the queries that matter. Section 37's rewriting method. Being cited in an Overview delivers brand exposure plus a link, and the click quality is higher.

4. Accept the zero-click impression as partial value. Being named in an answer with no click is real brand exposure, and it feeds the mention effect from Section 34. It is not nothing, and it is also not traffic. Do not let either overstatement stand.

5. Use the Generative AI Performance report. Search Console launched it in mid-2026 and it tracks performance inside AI Mode and AI Overviews. [confirmed] This is first-party Google data on a surface everyone else is estimating with third-party tools. Open it.

What not to do

- **Do not try to block AI Overviews.** nosnippet and max-snippet reduce or remove your eligibility, and the result is that a competitor is summarized instead of you. You lose the citation and keep the traffic decline.
- **Do not assume the decline is a penalty.** A traffic drop with stable rankings on informational queries is very likely this, not a core update. Section 41 and the diagnosis playbooks separate them.
- **Do not quote the 58% as an average.** It is a ceiling. Quoting it as typical is the kind of imprecision that gets caught.
- **Do not abandon SEO over this.** The blue links still exist, commercial intent still converts, and referred AI traffic converts better. The shape changed, not the existence.

Why this matters

this is the single change clients will ask about most, usually as "is SEO dead". The honest answer is specific: informational click volume is structurally down, commercial intent is resilient, AI-referred traffic converts several times better, and the citation slots are winnable by pages that do not rank. That answer is more useful and more credible than either panic or dismissal.

Do this now

- 1 **List 20 target queries** spanning informational and commercial intent.
- 2 **Search each one, logged out**, and record whether an AI Overview appears.
- 3 **For each Overview, record which sources are cited** and whether you are among them.
- 4 **Check whether the cited sources rank in the top 10.** Most will not.
- 5 **Split your list by intent** and compare AI Overview presence rates. Informational will be higher.
- 6 **Open Search Console and find the Generative AI Performance report.** Record your baseline AI impressions and clicks.
- 7 **Compare CTR now against 12 months ago** for your informational queries at stable positions. That gap is your measured exposure.
- 8 **Pick the three highest-value queries where an Overview appears and you are not cited.** Those are Section 37's work queue.

Capstone step

Your capstone has an AI Overview presence baseline across 20 target queries split by intent, a record of who is cited and whether they rank, a Search Console Generative AI Performance baseline, a measured CTR change on informational queries, and a prioritized list of three citation targets.

Key takeaways

- AI Overviews appear on **~47%** of results, **~60%** of searches end click-free, and CTR can fall **up to 58%**. That last figure is a ceiling, not an average.
- Informational traffic is structurally declining. Commercial and transactional intent is far more resilient, and AI-referred traffic converts **4 to 5x** better.
- Citation overlap with the organic top ten is **~38%** for Overviews and **14 to 17%** for AI Mode. You can be cited without ranking, and rank without being cited.
- Search Console's Generative AI Performance report is first-party data on this surface. Use it instead of estimating.